

Renovation Budget Shock Guide — Action Checklist

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GET REAL MATERIAL COSTS

- ☐ **Get Real Material Costs:** Call cabinet suppliers with your dimensions, not your budget, to get actual pricing for your specific kitchen layout and avoid anchoring to misleading national averages.
- ☐ **Get Real Material Costs:** Request delivered-and-installed flooring quotes from local stores instead of materials-only estimates so you know the true cost including labor, underlayment, and removal of old flooring.
- ☐ **Get Real Material Costs:** Browse Ferguson, Build.com, and MB Bertram wholesale supply websites for plumbing and electrical fixtures to access contractor-grade pricing that can cut fixture costs by 50%.
- ☐ **Get Real Material Costs:** Get template quotes from two stone yards for your countertop project so you understand the cost differences between quartz, granite, and laminate before deciding on materials.

BUILD FINANCIAL BUFFERS

- ☐ **Build Financial Buffers:** Apply a 30% contingency to your total budget if your home was built before 1980, has known issues, or will involve opening walls during construction.
- ☐ **Build Financial Buffers:** Apply a 20% contingency to your total budget if your home was built after 1980 with intact structure and no history of water damage or major DIY additions.
- ☐ **Build Financial Buffers:** Budget 1–3% of your total project cost for permit fees, which most contractors omit from initial estimates and which vary significantly by municipality and project type.
- ☐ **Build Financial Buffers:** Set aside \$1,500–\$5,000 for construction debris disposal, as hauling fees are a common blind spot that can derail an otherwise well-planned renovation budget.

CONTROL YOUR SCOPE

- ☐ **Control Your Scope:** Categorize every item on your renovation list as Tier 1, 2, or 3 to separate non-negotiable structural work from nice-to-have upgrades before finalizing your budget.

 - ☐ **Control Your Scope:** Build your initial budget using only Tier 1 non-negotiables and Tier 2 high-value improvements, reserving Tier 3 premium items for funding only if your contingency remains intact.

 - ☐ **Control Your Scope:** Use your tier system to evaluate change orders during construction, immediately identifying cosmetic upgrades as Tier 3 items that belong in a separate fund.

 - ☐ **Control Your Scope:** Defer all premium material upgrades and statement fixtures until your contingency survives the project completely intact to avoid debt or scope reduction on essential work.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.